Request for Information: Health Technology Ecosystem (CMS-0042-NC)
CMS-2025-0050-0031

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Department of Health and Human Services
Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services
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To Whom It May Concern,

Kinetik appreciates the opportunity to respond to the Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (CMS) and the Assistant Secretary for Technology Policy/Office of the National Coordinator for Health Information Technology (ASTP/ONC) Request for Information (CMS-0042-NC).

The Non-Emergency Medical Transportation industry represents a significant opportunity for Medicare and Medicare Advantage plans to enhance member outcomes and reduce long-term costs. While NEMT is critical for connecting vulnerable populations—especially those in Special Needs Plans—to essential care appointments, only 30% of MA plans currently offer this benefit in 2025 according to the Kaiser Family Foundation. Without reliable transportation access, members frequently miss preventive care visits, leading to delayed diagnoses, worsening chronic conditions, and overall driving up healthcare costs through potentially avoidable emergency interventions and hospitalization. Expanding NEMT coverage across Medicare and Medicare Advantage could create a more sustainable healthcare delivery model while improving member satisfaction and outcomes.

Investing in modern technology and streamlined systems is essential for improving the efficiency and reliability of NEMT services. By prioritizing innovation, CMS, State Medicaid Agencies and Managed Care Organizations can enhance the quality of care for vulnerable populations, reduce inefficiencies, and create a more accessible healthcare system for all.

As the nation's first digitally integrated healthcare transportation platform, Kinetik has demonstrated how technology can eliminate barriers to accessing care while creating transparency and peace of mind for members, families, and healthcare stakeholders. Our platform supports both transportation providers and health plans in enabling interoperable and member-centric care delivery. Through our direct experience serving Medicaid, Medicare and Medicare Advantage Special Needs plan members with diverse healthcare needs who rely on NEMT services, we have witnessed how real-time communication, proactive care coordination, and connected digital health solutions close critical gaps in access to care. In response to CMS's RFI (PC-1), we outline how digital health apps like Kinetik that enable non-emergency medical transportation can help individuals and their loved ones manage health needs and foster transparency and communication. We offer the following comments, drawn from our real-world experience developing and integrating digital tools for members, caregivers, payers, and providers.

PC-1. What health management or care navigation apps would help you understand and manage your (or your loved ones) health needs, as well as the actions you should take?

Transportation is a critical component to accessing care for the Medicare population. For many Medicare members, their ability to access needed care hinges on whether they have access to transportation. That means CMS, State Medicaid Agencies, and Health Plans have a responsibility to make requesting transportation as accessible and user-friendly as possible. Kinetik recommends the following components to assist Medicare members, their families, and loved ones in accessing transportation to connect to care.

Request and Manage NEMT Rides

- Need: More flexible options for Members and their caregivers to request rides and manage their NEMT benefit. Members and their caregivers are often required to make a phone call to request a ride.
- Solution: The Kinetik digital health app allows users to request NEMT rides directly at their convenience (24/7) through a user-friendly interface. The app verifies eligibility and schedules rides with preferred transportation providers. Users are prompted to answer a series of questions that ensure the most appropriate mode of transportation is sourced - this includes an opportunity to add any special instructions, such as “member requires extra time to descend stairs” or “needs wheelchair-accessible vehicle,” ensuring tailored accommodations.
- Impact: Kinetik meets members where they are by offering options for managing their transportation benefit. This streamlines access to care, reduces missed appointments, and enhances member autonomy, especially for those with mobility or chronic health needs.

Real-Time Ride Status and Driver Tracking

- Need: Uncertainty about transportation status or difficulties connecting with the driver leads to frequent calls inquiring, “Where’s my ride?” This creates administrative burdens and unnecessary member anxiety.
- Solution: The Kinetik member app provides real-time updates on ride status (e.g., “Driver assigned,” “En route,” “Arrived”) and allows users to track their driver’s location on a map, similar to ride-sharing platforms. This transparency reduces uncertainty and empowers users to plan accordingly. For example, a member could see that their driver is 10 minutes away and prepare to leave.
- Impact: Decreases call volume to health plans, enhances the member experience, and improves efficiency for NEMT providers.

a. What are the top things you would like to be able to do for your or your loved ones' health that can be enabled by digital health products?

An issue that Kinetik has identified among key NEMT stakeholders, such as care coordinators, family members, and loved ones, is the lack of visibility to ensure the member and/or loved one has made their way to their medical appointment safely. In a technological world where individuals are able to track their burrito being made, getting picked up, estimated time of arrival, and where the driver is, there is no excuse as to why this same technology isn't available for Medicare members and their loved ones to track their medical ride. Kinetik has made this possible with our fully digitized, interoperable closed-loop ecosystem, ensuring our Member App is capable of delivering complete transparency to members and their loved ones. Empowering members to take ownership of their healthcare journey with an intuitive tool offers peace of mind to all including the members themselves, their care coordinators, family members, and loved ones.

Safety and Communication with Care Coordinators and Loved Ones

- Need: members and caregivers value safety, security, and the ability to keep others informed during medical transportation.
- Solution: The Kinetik platform enables users to notify care coordinators, family members, or loved ones when they begin their ride, sharing details such as the estimated arrival time. Authorized individuals can track the ride's progress in real-time via the app, ensuring peace of mind. For instance, a caregiver could receive an alert when their loved one boards the ride and monitor their location until they reach the medical facility.
- Impact: Enhances safety, builds trust in NEMT services, and fosters collaboration among members, caregivers, and care teams.

Kinetik is dedicated to advancing digital health solutions that empower members, their families and caregivers by ensuring non-emergency medical transportation (NEMT) is accessible, transparent, and secure. Our platform streamlines ride scheduling, real-time tracking, and communication, reducing barriers to care and easing administrative burdens for health plans. We are eager to partner with CMS to enhance these solutions and drive better health outcomes for all. Kinetik supports CMS and ASTP/ONC's efforts to build a modern, scalable, and member-centered digital health infrastructure. We welcome opportunities to collaborate on policy development, technical pilots, and real-world implementation to improve outcomes for all beneficiaries.

TD-13 What new opportunities and advancements could emerge with APIs providing access to the entirety of a patient's electronic health information (EHI)?

Universal API access to complete member Electronic Health Information (EHI) would enable comprehensive care coordination across the entire healthcare ecosystem. Currently, critical data points are siloed - a member's transportation history, specialist visits, emergency room encounters, and routine checkups exist in separate systems that don't communicate. With full

EHI access, every touchpoint in a member's journey could be digitized and connected end-to-end.

It is a common occurrence for a hospital to pay for a taxi cab to discharge their member to free up their bed to a new patient instead of waiting the typical 48-hour window of NEMT request and ride fulfillment. Imagine if a discharge coordinator were able to request an on-demand NEMT trip right from a member's EHI and hospital workflow system. Not only would it save time and resources on sourcing a ride, but it would log this data point in the EHI. Additionally, it could develop algorithms to automatically prompt, or even schedule a trip for members if they do not have their own transportation.

This interoperability would transform healthcare delivery by ensuring providers have complete member context, reducing medical errors caused by incomplete information, and enabling predictive analytics to identify care gaps before they become crises. For NEMT providers like Kinetik, transportation patterns could reveal health trends, medication adherence issues, or social determinants of health that impact member outcomes.

The resulting ecosystem optimization would free up resources currently wasted on manual data entry and phone calls, allowing healthcare workers to focus on high-value member care activities. This efficiency translates directly to improved health outcomes and reduced costs across the system.

a. **What are the primary obstacles to this?**

The fundamental challenge is that the current system incentivizes data hoarding rather than sharing. Major EHI vendors have built profitable business models around proprietary systems that make integration deliberately expensive and complex. These companies may not see immediate value in facilitating seamless data exchange, particularly with smaller healthcare technology companies.

Financial barriers are significant, especially for healthcare startups and smaller organizations. API integration costs, certification fees, and ongoing maintenance expenses can reach hundreds of thousands of dollars annually. This creates a barrier to entry that favors established players over innovative solutions.

Data integrity concerns compound these challenges. Too many healthcare processes still rely on manual data transfer - members filling out forms in pen, faxing documents between providers, or phone-based information sharing. Each human handoff introduces opportunities for error, creating a "telephone game" effect with critical health information.

The irony is that members routinely share personal data for minimal benefits - discount coupons, social media engagement, or convenience features - yet the healthcare system treats their medical information as if safely and appropriately sharing it for better care coordination is inherently problematic. Most members would gladly share their health data if it meant more effective treatment and better health outcomes.

Breaking this cycle requires cooperation from major EHI vendors, regulatory alignment, and a fundamental shift toward viewing comprehensive data sharing as essential infrastructure rather than a competitive advantage. The stakes are too high to continue tolerating fragmented systems. Policy must prioritize accurate information sharing and coordinated care to project millions of lives.

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